# ENT EMERGENCIES AND THEIR MANAGEMENT

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## INTRODUCTION

Ear, nose and throat emergencies are frequently encountered in casualty departments. Many can be managed by a general doctor if recognised early.

## EAR EMERGENCY: ACUTE MASTOIDITIS

Acute mastoiditis is a serious condition that needs urgent assessment by the ENT team and close monitoring in hospital.

### A. Initial stabilisation

• Assess airway, breathing and circulation, and monitor vital signs. • Establish intravenous access if the patient is systemically unwell.

### B. Medical treatment

• Start empiric intravenous antibiotics promptly according to local hospital guidelines. • Give analgesia and antipyretics as needed.

### C. Surgical treatment

Surgical intervention may be required when there is a subperiosteal abscess or coalescent mastoiditis. Potential complications include facial nerve palsy, meningitis and intracranial abscess.

## NOSE EMERGENCY: SEVERE EPISTAXIS

Severe epistaxis is a serious condition that needs urgent assessment by the ENT team and close monitoring in hospital.

### A. Immediate first aid

• Sit the patient upright and lean them forward to minimise swallowing of blood. • Apply firm pressure to the soft part of the nose for 10 to 15 minutes.

### B. Definitive control

Anterior bleeding can be cauterised with silver nitrate. Persistent or posterior bleeding needs urgent ENT intervention to prevent significant blood loss.

## CONCLUSION

Prompt recognition and early referral are the keys to safe management of ENT emergencies.

## REFERENCES

1. Example A. Epistaxis management. J Example ENT. 2020;1:1-5.